

OBJECTION OVERRULED: KSU
activists being beaten up by the police



MATTERS OF FAITH

The LDF Government is drawing flak from religious heads over the state women's commission's recommendations to end human rights violations against nuns, and the contents of a new textbook

■ By **M.G. Radhakrishnan**

Religion is a tricky issue at the best of times, and now it's got Kerala in an uproar following recommendations by the State Women's Commission to ostensibly end the so-called violations of human rights faced by nuns. The report has wildly angered church leaders in the state and put the state Government in a dilemma. The Commission's three recommendations to the state Government, after it received a complaint of exploitation faced by nuns inside the church, were: fix 18 years as the minimum age for enrolment as nuns and initiate legal action against parents who send underaged daughters to nunneries; protect the family wealth

and property of girls who join nunneries and discourage the practice of donating property to the congregations they join; and formulate rehabilitation packages for nuns who quit or retire from the vocation.

Barely an hour after the recommendations were announced, the supreme heads of almost all the different churches in the state trashed them unanimously. "It is absurd. The Commission has shown total ignorance," says Major Archbishop Moran Mor Baselios Cleemis of the Syro-Malankara Catholic Church. "No church allows a woman to become a nun before the age of 18 as it is forbidden by canonical laws. Nobody is either forced to take up the vocation or disallowed from quitting. Neither are

they made to donate their property to the congregation," said a statement issued by the Catholic Bishop's Conference of India and the Opposition Congress against the recommendations of the Commission, which was appointed by the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government. "This is yet another assault by the Marxist-led Government against the minority Christian community. We will fight it tooth and nail," says Ramesh Chennithala, president of the state Congress.

The party has also pointed out that the Commission has no Christian representation as none of the four members are from the community and the members are political nominees of LDF's constituents. Justice D. Sreedevi, who heads the commission, said they